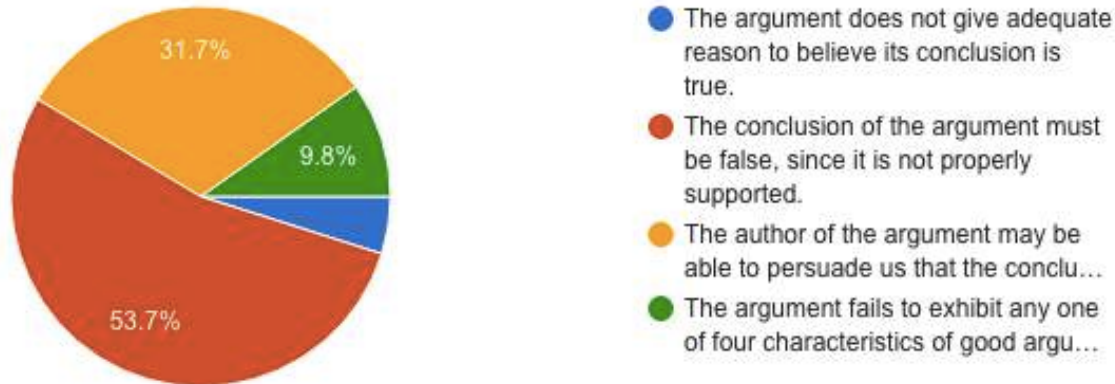


- **Important clarification:** A fallacious argument fails to support its conclusion – but *that doesn't mean that the conclusion must be false*.

1. Which of the following is **not** true of a fallacious argument? (41 responses)



- About half of the class grasped the point of this clarification: **an argument that commits a fallacy does *not* necessarily have a false conclusion**.
- About 32% of you did not quite grasp the implication that **if an argument defending a particular conclusion turns out to be faulty, another argument might prove successful in defending the truth of the same conclusion**.
- E.g., for the conclusion that *cats are the best pets*, the argument:
Cats are the best pets because I love my cat
 - ...doesn't not succeed in defending the truth of the conclusion (because it commits a non-sequitur), but a different argument with an alternative premise might be capable of persuading us of the truth of its conclusion:
Cats are the best pets because they are both intimately affectionate & able to take care of their needs independently from humans.



➤ **Begging the Question** (a.k.a. **Circular Argumentation**)

is when an author presupposes the truth of the conclusion in the reasoning they provide in defense of that conclusion.

- » This form of reasoning fails to support its conclusion because it just re-asserts the conclusion in its premise instead of providing independent reasons to believe the conclusion is true.

➤ **Not every fallacious argument is an instance of begging the question.**

– Some **good examples of circular reasoning** from among your submissions:

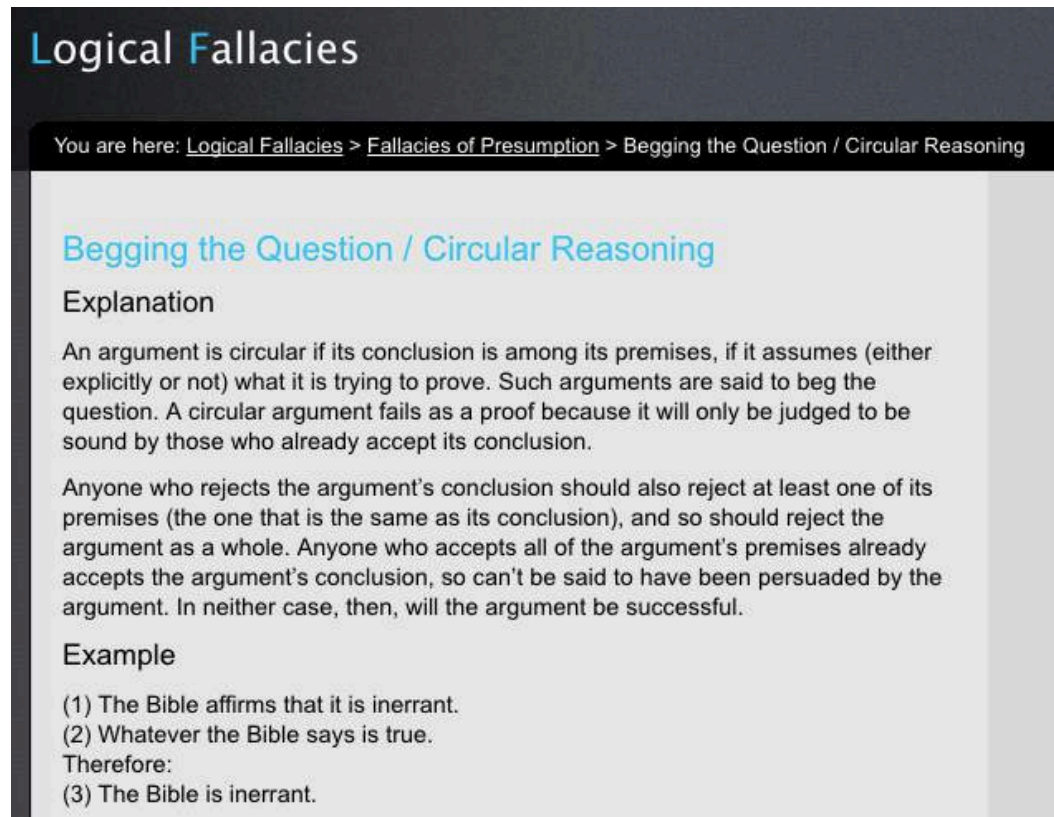
- *The egg comes before the chicken because the chicken comes from the egg.*
 - The premise (the chicken comes from the egg) assumes that the conclusion (the egg comes before the chicken) is true.
- *My brother is adorable because he is cute.*
 - The premise (he [my brother] is cute) assumes the conclusion (my brother is adorable) is true.
- *He is rich because he has a lot of money.*
- *The Bible is the word of God because God tells us it is... in the Bible.*
- *Climate Change doesn't exist because the climate doesn't change.*

Some less successful examples:

- *The Bible affirms that it is inerrant. Whatever the Bible says is true.
Therefore: The Bible is inerrant.*
 - This is an example of begging the question, but **I asked for your own example**, meaning one that you came up with by yourself.
 - **This does not count as “your own” example:** it comes from one of the first pages that comes up when you search “begging the question” on Google:

When I ask for your own example,
or for you to explain something
in your own words,
I really mean your own.

- It's ok to do some additional research on the internet to gain inspiration or to deepen your understanding of what we are studying, but **to get full credit on questions that ask for “your own” input on exams, you will need to use your intelligence to answer the question.**
 - If you must use work that is not your own, CITE THE SOURCE.



Logical Fallacies

You are here: [Logical Fallacies](#) > [Fallacies of Presumption](#) > [Begging the Question / Circular Reasoning](#)

Begging the Question / Circular Reasoning

Explanation

An argument is circular if its conclusion is among its premises, if it assumes (either explicitly or not) what it is trying to prove. Such arguments are said to beg the question. A circular argument fails as a proof because it will only be judged to be sound by those who already accept its conclusion.

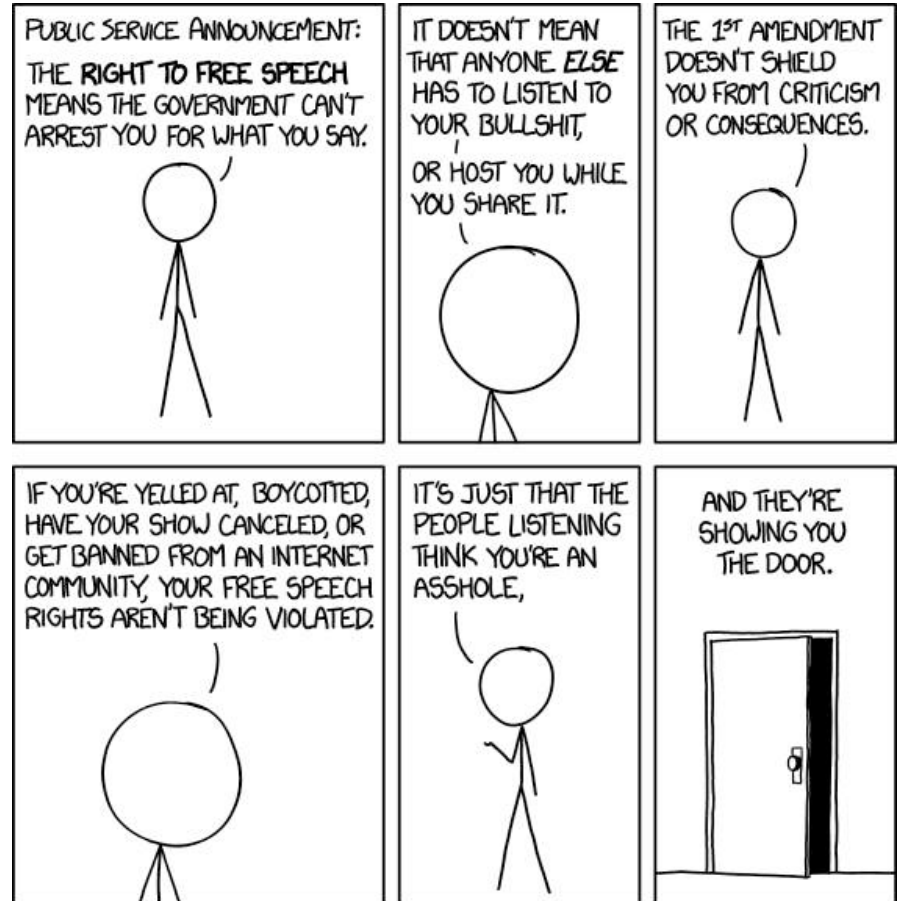
Anyone who rejects the argument's conclusion should also reject at least one of its premises (the one that is the same as its conclusion), and so should reject the argument as a whole. Anyone who accepts all of the argument's premises already accepts the argument's conclusion, so can't be said to have been persuaded by the argument. In neither case, then, will the argument be successful.

Example

(1) The Bible affirms that it is inerrant.
(2) Whatever the Bible says is true.
Therefore:
(3) The Bible is inerrant.

Some examples we can learn something from:

- *Killing people is wrong, so the death penalty is wrong.*
 - This argument has what we call a “hidden premise”: its conclusion depends upon an unstated assumption, namely that *the death penalty involves killing people*.
 - It doesn't *quite* assume the truth of the conclusion, because *the death penalty is wrong* could be true for reasons other than that *killing people is wrong*.
 - To truly beg the question, it must be the case that the conclusion could not be true unless the premise were true.
- *I deserve to pass this class, so you should give me an A.*
 - The premise doesn't quite assume the truth of the conclusion exactly as written; instead, it assumes that *you should give me any passing grade (A, B, C, D)*.
- *Everyone has freedom of speech, so I can say whatever I want.*
 - If the conclusion is revised to *I can say whatever I want without being arrested by the government*, this is a great example of circular reasoning (see the comic for clarification.)



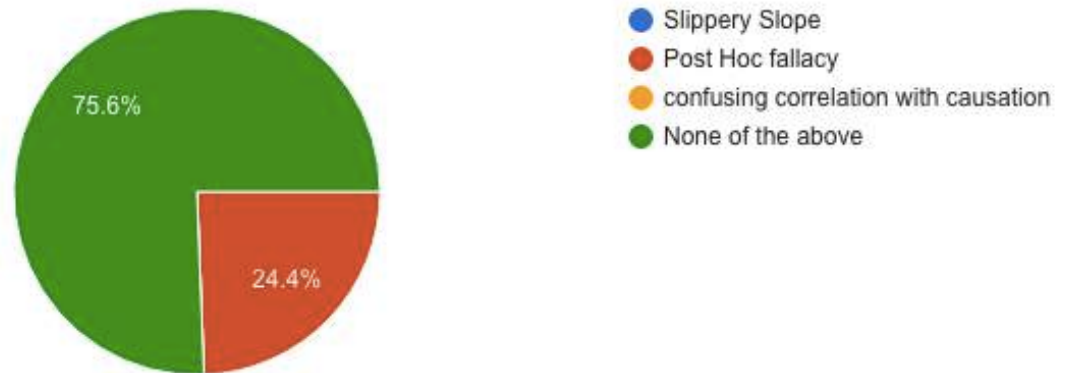
➤ A ***Non Sequitur*** (Latin for 'it doesn't follow') is when an author draws a conclusion that simply isn't supported by the reasoning they have given to support it.

- This fallacy is a catch-all term for patterns of reasoning that draw an arbitrary conclusion from the premises without properly considering & ruling out alternative conclusions that could just as easily be drawn from the evidence at hand.

➤ **Confusing Chronology with Causation** (a.k.a. ***Post Hoc Fallacy***) is when an author mistakenly assumes that since one event comes after another, the first event must have *caused* the second to occur.

➤ This is technically a subtype of ***Non-Sequitur***, where one arbitrarily jumps to the conclusion that since event X occurred prior to event Y, X brought about Y.

3. Which of these fallacies is **not** a variety of Non Sequitur? (41 responses)



➤ So: Slippery Slopes, the Post Hoc fallacy, & Confusing Correlation with Causation are all varieties of Non-Sequiturs.